

Winter Bean Soup

Prep: 30 minutes, plus soaking time

Cook: About 2 hours

Makes 4 servings

2 tablespoons olive oil
2 leeks, white and pale green sliced into matchsticks, soaked, drained, dried
2 carrots, chopped
2 celery ribs, chopped
2 garlic cloves, finely chopped
Kosher salt AND freshly ground black pepper
½ teaspoon crushed red pepper flakes

1 sprig EACH: fresh rosemary, fresh thyme
1 bay leaf
3 cups plumped cannellini beans (see note)
½ cup cubed ham
½ cup canned diced tomatoes
2 quarts chicken broth
2 cups thinly sliced lacinato kale leaves
Freshly grated Parmesan cheese

Note: Cover ½ pound dried cannellini beans with cold water and let soak overnight, drain and rinse; OR cover ½ pound dried beans with cold water, boil 1 minute, let soak 1 hour, drain and rinse; OR open 2 15-ounce cans of cannellini beans, drain and rinse. (If using canned beans, add only ½ teaspoon salt to sautéed vegetables; taste before adding more.)

In a large pot, heat oil over medium-low. Add leeks, carrots, celery and garlic. Cook, stirring, until vegetables are softened and fragrant, about 8 minutes. Season with 1 teaspoon salt, ½ teaspoon black pepper and the crushed red pepper.

Tie together rosemary, thyme and bay leaf; toss this bundle into the pot. Stir in beans, ham and tomatoes. Pour in 6 cups broth. Bring to a boil, lower to a simmer. Cover and let simmer until beans turn tender and flavorful, about 1 hour 45 minutes for dried beans, about 30 minutes for canned.

As the beans simmer, add some of the remaining broth, if needed. The goal is a broth swimming with beans, not a thick chili-style mash.

When beans are tender, taste the broth and season with more salt and pepper, if needed. Discard herb bundle. Stir in kale, cover, and cook until tender, about 10 minutes. Scoop soup into bowls. Dust with Parmesan. Enjoy hot.